

■ By Deepika Khatri

A cement floor becomes a black-board, a fridge is bought with what looks like Monopoly currency and hopscotch gets a twist with numbers written in boxes to be identified as children skip along. It's summertime and school is over, but 20 km off the eight-lane Delhi-Jaipur expressway in Kankrola village, Haryana, 70

children between the ages of six and 10 are at a Pratham summer camp. Three hours a day, seven days a week, their voices drown out the cries of peacocks as they chant tables under a banyan tree in a quarter acre compound bordered by shahtoos, pipal and neem trees. Six-year-old Nikita looks forward to her reading class, *Chand Aur Tare*, her favourite story. Santosh Shivendre has learnt to write her name and painstakingly practices numbers from one to 100 everyday, but doesn't know how old she is.

It's a world away from Mumbai's slums, where Madhav Chavan and Farida Lambay started Pratham in 1994, a product of the

Bombay Educational Initiative by UNICEF. With a Rs 2-lakh budget, 100 centres with 25 children in each at the beginning and a vision to universalise primary education, they never imagined that 14 years later, this non-profit organisation would have a pan-India reach, touching the lives of 17 million children in 370 districts in 19 states.

"The insanity of the Mumbai riots of 1992-93 had left an aftertaste of pessimism and mistrust. I felt education centres would become places of sanity and bring a sense

BASIC FOUNDATION: Children at a Pratham camp in Kankrola village in Haryana

learning CURVE

✱ Pratham

Project Making primary education accessible across the country

Can-do Icon Armaity Desai, the former UGC chairperson, for her humility and commitment

40 per cent students drop out before reaching Class V



REUBEN SINGH